

CHAPTER II

WORKS

THE principal writings of Maimonides in chronological order are the following:

Spanish period (1148-1160: *aetat.* 13-25):

Introduction to Logic;

Talmudic Commentaries (practically disappeared);

Essay on the Jewish Calendar, 1158;

Mishnah Commentary (begun).

Fez (1160-1165: *aetat.* 25-30):

Letter on Apostasy (1160).

Egypt (1165-1204: *aetat.* 30-69):

Mishnah Commentary (completed, revised and published), 1168;

Book of Precepts, 1170;

Letter to the Yemen, 1172;

Mishneh Torah (= "Repetition of the Law"), 1170-80;

Guide for the Perplexed, 1190;

Letter on Astrology, 1194.

In addition to the above there are a number of medical writings attributed to him, of which, according to the latest authority, Dr. Suessmann Muntner, eight are genuine. These include both specialist studies (e.g., that on asthma now published by Dr. Muntner) and general chapters on diet and health. Those specially interested may be referred to the books and articles of Dr. Muntner; the essay of W. M. Feldman in the *Maimonides VIII Centenary Memorial Volume* (ed. I. Epstein), London, 1935; that of Max Meyerhof in *Essays on Maimonides* (ed. S. W. Baron), Columbia University Press, 1941; and H. Friedenwald, *Jewish Luminaries in Medical History*, Johns Hopkins Press, 1946. There is extant also a considerable

body of Maimonides' Responsa and learned correspondence, of which the latest and fullest edition is that by Aaron Freimann (Jerusalem, 1941).

Introduction to Logic (Arabic and Hebrew texts with English translation by I. Efros, New York, 1938).

This is said to be Maimonides' first book, written at the age of sixteen. If this is true, it is a most remarkable achievement. The book is a concise exposition of over two hundred technical terms of the Aristotelian logic and metaphysics in clearly defined chapters—on propositions, their parts and their formal and material classification; inference, immediate and mediate (syllogism); moods and figures of the syllogism; first principles and causes; predicables and categories; potentiality and actuality; contraries, privation, relation, correlation; priority, temporal and logical; synonyms, heteronyms, homonyms, metaphors, and univocal and equivocal terms; and finally a classification of the arts and sciences and of philosophy and its various branches, theoretical and applied.

The *Introduction to Logic* is by design so short as to be little more than a vocabulary. But its conciseness is admirable and it still has value for the young student. It has also a further use, as was remarked forcibly by the editor of the first printed edition (Basel, 1526), the Christian humanist Sebastian Munster. Although written originally in Arabic, it was soon translated into Hebrew and became the norm for Hebrew philosophical terminology. It thus remains in spite of its brevity the handiest introduction to Jewish medieval thought.

With the *Introduction to Logic* it will be convenient to group the *Essay on the Calendar*. This essay, written originally in Arabic but known to us only in the Hebrew version, is a brief account of the somewhat complicated Jewish method of reckoning chronology. Its complication is due to the fact that the Jewish religious year, although lunar in its basis, is yet dependent on the seasons of the sun: the feast of Passover, e.g., is in the "month of the spring" (*Abib*, Exod. xxxiv, 18); Pentecost, at the time of the "first fruits of the wheat harvest"; Tabernacles, at the "ingathering at the year's end." It is thus

in effect a solar year made up of lunar months. The resulting necessity of intercalation is common to most ancient calendars, and the mathematical calculations on which the Jewish system is based go back to the Athenian astronomer Meton (432 B.C.). Apart from some difficult special adjustments due to considerations of convenience in fixing the days of certain festivals, the Jewish method was standardized at an early period. Yet it seems to have been kept in the hands of the religious authorities, who fixed the dates of the festivals year by year.

Maimonides explains the whole system briefly and sensibly under two heads. The first, consisting of seven chapters, covers principally the lunar aspect and the immediate problems of calendar calculation, the second, of three chapters, the wider problems of the solar cycle, the calculation of the equinox, and so on. He wastes little time on preliminaries. The basic points and figures are given at once and the method of calculation explained. It is characteristic that at every stage he gives tables in order to aid the memory of the student, and advises him to learn the subject thoroughly by making his own calculations and then checking them by the tables given.

Talmudic Commentaries

Our knowledge of these writings is based principally on Maimonides' own testimony. In the introduction to the *Mishnah Commentary* (below, p. 24) he says that he had composed a commentary to the tractate *Hullin* of the Babylonian Talmud (a very difficult treatise dealing principally with the laws of the ritual slaughter of animals and their use for food) "because of the great need of it" and to three "orders" (each containing several treatises), also from the Babylonian Talmud, of civil and religious law.

In the course of the same *Mishnah Commentary* (Tamid V, I) he refers to his "Decisions from the Jerusalem Talmud," and from another reference in a letter it would seem that this work was patterned on the Decisions of Isaac of Fez (1013-1103) which is a practical digest of the Babylonian Talmud following its original order but omitting all argument and discussion or illustrative reference and confining itself to issues relevant to daily living. This book of Isaac of Fez, commonly

called the "Alfasi," became authoritative as a source-book of decisions from the *Babylonian* Talmud, and it is thought that the young Maimonides aimed at producing a similar, and similarly authoritative, digest of the Talmud of *Jerusalem*.

Of these Rabbinic writings only insignificant fragments have survived and we can say little definite about them, but the very fact of their composition is of extreme interest and deserves consideration.

It should be noted, first, that they are mentioned by Maimonides as finished before he set to work on his *Mishnah Commentary*, and he did this at the age of twenty-three. He must have undertaken these tasks then between the ages of thirteen and twenty-three, during the ten years in which with his father and family he was wandering from place to place in south Spain. It would thus appear that already as a youth Maimonides felt a mission, and in spite of the most adverse circumstances set to work to fulfil it. What that mission was we can only suggest when we have surveyed his career to the end, but it would appear to have involved from the first a definite task of exposition.

But the exposition was to be of a practical character. The tractates of the *Babylonian* Talmud he chose were those which had relevance to the life of the community—regulations concerning feast and fast, marriage and divorce, the detail of civil and criminal law. His treatment of the *Jerusalem* Talmud, if the accepted theory is true, was even more significant. Obscure and tortuous in language, fragmentary and faulty in text, the *Jerusalem* Talmud is only now beginning to become clear, and not least by the labours of our own contemporary scholars. But it was this sealed book that the young wandering student proposed to open for the use of his own day, not however by way of detailed commentary but by that of a digest, that is, a handbook for practical reference.

It is suggested by a remark of Maimonides himself in a late letter (II, 44a) that these works of his have vanished because he had no leisure to revise them properly for publication. But another reason might be submitted in view of what was to come. The need for these and similar writings disappeared with Maimonides' own further labours.

Mishnah Commentary (referred to hereafter as the *Commentary*).

This is the first major work of Maimonides which has survived. It took ten years to complete and it became standard at once. In its Hebrew translation (it was written originally in Arabic) it has been reprinted indefinitely and is now found in every edition of the Talmud, while a modern scientific edition of the Arabic original has been recently completed.

The *Mishnah* (see above, p. 17) is the first post-Biblical Jewish code. It was drawn up by the official heads of Palestine Jewry at a time of severe spiritual disintegration, and it would seem to have constituted an attempt to halt that disintegration. It is the authoritative summary of past achievement and is the next important stage in the self-consolidation of Judaism after the closing of the canon of the Bible. We need not enter into its contents here. It is sufficient to explain that it is a survey of the regulations obtaining within the living Jewish population of Palestine during the first two centuries of the current era. It is not (at least in its present form) a bare legal code. It contains many incidental references to other matters and one whole treatise, the Sayings of the Fathers, definitely devoted to morals. But it is legal in its succinctness. It eschews explanation. It is compressed, often to a fault.

Maimonides' commentary is the first complete and specific commentary written to the *Mishnah*. Yet, although a first attempt, it fulfils admirably most of the functions of a commentary: it explains difficult terms and obscure passages and seeks to bring together apparent discrepancies. But it does something more too, and it is this something more which makes it unique.

First of all it summarizes, and (as it were) brings "up to date," each regulation or set of regulations in accordance with the later (Talmudic) decisions. Maimonides was no student of law for its own sake. Law was for life, and life moves on. Any doubt or ambiguity in the early book must be therefore cleared up, any omission supplied. And Maimonides in case of doubt or change gives the latest view; in some cases, greatly daring, he gave his own. But he went further than this. He tried to reveal the principle behind a decision or a group of

decisions. Again his reason for doing this was practical. A principle once fixed could be used for the solution of fresh questions not mentioned in the original code. This attempt gives a peculiar flavour to the *Commentary*. Its effect is not only to adapt the *Mishnah* to later needs but to base it on fundamental principles of legal thinking.

Nor did Maimonides confine this attempt to the purely legal side. Any broad issue stimulated him to special reflection. Indeed the characteristic part of the whole work lies in the numerous introductions and excursions. The *Mishnah* is a legal code based on tradition—but what is tradition? Maimonides opens the *Commentary* with a long introductory chapter in explanation of what tradition is. The *Mishnah* contains a whole Order dealing with the laws of ritual purity, and one tractate describing Temple offerings. Maimonides must explain what ritual purity means, and what the different types of offering were. The *Mishnah* includes, as we have seen, an ethical treatise, the Sayings of the Fathers. Maimonides must not only explain those Sayings (and he adds many shrewd observations, and indeed, many small homilies, of his own). Practical ethics, the training of man to do the right, is dependent on the nature of man, so Maimonides writes *Eight Chapters* on psychology (available in an English version by J. I. Gorfinkle, Columbia University Press, 1912), explaining the nature of man and its ethical consequences. The most remarkable excursus of all is one on theology. In one place, and in one place only, the *Mishnah* enters into the field of dogmatics. It declares almost casually that certain classes of transgressors have “no part in the world to come.” At that Maimonides is stirred to the composition of a special chapter on the “world to come” which is in effect an essay in rational theology. We may leave this now, as we shall have occasion later to make special reference to it (p. 111 ff). It should be noted however that, after the general essay in rational theology, Maimonides offered a chapter of dogmatics himself, and laid down “thirteen articles” of belief which became a centre of contention both among his opponents and his supporters, but which were responsible in no small measure for the preservation of Judaism as a theistic creed down to our own day.

The *Mishnah Commentary*, begun during the years of wandering in Spain and continued at Fez, was completed and revised for publication only in 1168, three years after Maimonides had settled in Egypt. A pathetic passage at the end gives these dates and asks pardon for errors since the work was done "in exile and wandering from one end of the earth to the other, parts of it during journeys on land, others while going in ships on the sea."

Letter on Apostasy

This small work, written under the influence of a letter of his father, Maimon, on the same general occasion, is significant, as it shows that Maimonides' mind was always working with the higher issues in view. The problem was one unfortunately only too familiar to himself and his family, how to act in the face of the alternative, so often presented to the Jews of the time, between death and conversion to Islam; but its form was new and (as we know now) fateful. Most Moroccan Jews, unable to seize either horn of the dilemma, had chosen the middle way of outward conformity: they made the Moslem profession of faith and paid the required weekly visit to the Mosque while they remained Jews at heart and maintained at home the practices of Judaism. An opinion on this line of conduct had been asked from a Rabbinical authority living safely elsewhere, and he had replied denouncing it and declaring that such renegades were no better than idolaters and should be treated as such. This cruel reply seems to have created a tense situation, and Maimonides intervened.

In view of his own actions in similar circumstances, Maimonides could point out without selfrighteousness that the principal duty of Jews who found themselves in such a quandary was to seek a country in which they could live a Jewish life openly and undisturbed. But he was realist enough to know that all men are not heroes and that self-preservation is the first rule of life. He laid it down, therefore, quoting Talmudic authority and historical precedents, that this external conformity did not exclude them from the community of Israel. Islam is not idolatry, and the repetition of its profession of faith, although wrong for a Jew, is not a capital offence. The brethren

had erred, but they were still brethren. A Jew may sin, but he remains a Jew.

The theory of external conformity which received here Maimonides' support has a long history from Ahasuerus' Queen (Esther, caps. ii and iv) to the Marranos of fifteenth, sixteenth and seventeenth century Spain, and he would be a bold man to decide whether it has worked finally for good or for evil. But there is no doubt on which side lie the claims of humanity, and it was on that side that Maimonides, arming himself with all the authority derived from his immense learning, argued unanswerably.

With the *Letter on Apostasy* we may well link an even more famous letter written in Egypt some ten years or more later, the *Epistle to the Yemen* or the *Gate of Hope*. This letter presents Maimonides in a slightly different guise. In the *Letter on Apostasy* he speaks rather as a Talmudist giving a definite ruling on a point of law. In the *Epistle to the Yemen* he is a public leader giving hope and encouragement to a distant and suffering community. The tone is one of sympathy. It is a call to pride, pride in the past, confidence in the future. It is serene with the high serenity of the prophetic conviction which he quotes, that just as "God does not change" so the "sons of Israel will not be consumed."

"Strengthen ye the weak hands and confirm the feeble knees . . . Know that this is the true Divine Law given us by the chiefest of all the prophets first and last¹, and that by this Law we have been set apart from all men, not for our deserts but because of His loving kindness and bounty . . . And for that He made us unique by His commandments and laws, all worshippers of other gods have been greatly jealous of us . . . and have sought to destroy our Law and uproot our faith; some by the sword and some by argument . . . Yet it shall not come to pass . . . since no weapon that is formed against thee shall prosper, and every tongue that riseth up against thee thou shalt confute . . ."

¹ It should be remarked in passing that Maimonides' constant emphasis on the pre-eminent place of Moses among all the prophets both before and after would seem to be in oblique reference to Mohammed.

So the letter goes on in a wonderful stream of exhortation and encouragement, sweetened at every turn by Biblical verses which even now stir the blood. The stumblers must be strengthened. If they fall, they show themselves not of the seed of Israel. The true Israel marches on proudly, secure in his faith and guided by his God.

Maimonides concludes by laying down the principles of the faith, in which he called them all, young and old, individuals and whole communities, to join together in strengthening one another: "Attach your nation to a true thing which shall not alter or be destroyed, and raise your voices in a faith which shall never falter or fail. Proclaim to the world that God is uniquely one and that Moses is his prophet and head and foremost of all the prophets, both before and after; and that this book of the Law is all of it the word of God given to Moses, not to be annulled or changed, or added to or subtracted from, for ever . . . In this covenant stay ye ; by this religion hold fast; in this your faith remain."

The Book of Precepts

With this book we go back to Maimonides the Talmudist. The *Book of Precepts* is a rational attempt to classify and systematize the approach to Jewish Law considered as one continuous and historic tradition. According to a passage in the Talmud, the number of Pentateuchal precepts, positive and negative together, amounts to six hundred and thirteen, and on the basis of this dictum lists of primary commandments had been drawn up, many of them by the poets for synagogue use and edification. Maimonides complains, rightly, that sound definitions were always absent, and with them a sound principle of classification. The results were therefore deplorable even in certain standard books by scholars of authority. So Maimonides set to work to begin the enquiry afresh, and he did it by laying down logical rules for distinguishing fundamental commands.

But, as ever, the enquiry was no abstract one undertaken in the interest of pure science. It was severely practical and written with a definitely practical object in view. The fact is that the *Book of Precepts* is only an introduction to the book

we are to discuss immediately, the *Mishneh Torah* (the Repetition of the Law), which in itself is only the completion of the idea we have seen already to have been present to his mind in the Mishnah Commentary. This time we have no need for conjecture as to his purpose, since he explains it plainly himself.

In the *Commentary on the Mishnah*, he says in his introduction to the *Book of Precepts*, his aim was to make clear the traditional law, not however to enter into the detail of each commandment and to lay down what is allowed and what is forbidden in each case. This was reserved for a future work which would contain all the regulations of the traditional law in their completeness and entirety. This work would omit all reference to the discussions which form the basis of the decisions in Talmudic literature, or to individual opinions which carry no general authority, and would give plainly the final decision on all points.

But, he continues, as soon as he had formulated this plan clearly in his mind, the question arose how he should carry it out. Should he just follow the order of the *Mishnah*¹; or should he set up an order of his own, introducing each subject in accordance with a sound logical and pedagogical approach and grouping all laws round their root ideas. Deciding on the latter course, he found it essential to classify the traditional law: and this book, the *Book of Precepts*, was the result. It is thus an introduction to the *Mishneh Torah*. It was written in Arabic (the *Mishneh Torah* was written in pure Mishnaic Hebrew), possibly, as has been suggested, in order to prevent its being treated as an actual part of the *Mishneh Torah*. But its classification of the laws is that on which the *Mishneh Torah* is arranged. On the one point in particular which makes all the writings of Maimonides especially significant to the student of religious thought in general and of Judaism in particular, the *Book of Precepts* and *Mishneh Torah* are one. They both start with a group of theological doctrines. The first of the positive commandments, which Maimonides puts first because it is the root of them all, is the belief in the existence of God, and after it there are ranged in order the

¹ See pp. 17, 24 above.

belief in God's unity (2), and the duty of the love (3) and the fear (4) of God, and of worshipping him alone (5). Maimonides then lays it down (quoting earlier authority), that worship means not only prayer but study. The sixth primary commandment becomes therefore the duty of association with learned men, "as it is written once and again: 'and to cleave unto Him'; and the *Sifre* [an old juristic commentary to parts of the Pentateuch] comments—'and to cleave unto Him: that is, cleave to the wise and their disciples'."

In this passage is struck one of the main notes in the outlook both of Maimonides himself and of the Judaism which he both so fully represented and in his turn so forcefully helped to mould. It is rationalistic, intellectualistic, but emotionally so. The intellectual recognition of the Divine unity leads to the love and fear of God, and knowledge, love and fear flower together in worship.

The *Mishneh Torah* (referred to hereafter as the *Code*), planned in accordance with the classification laid down in the *Book of Precepts*, is divided into fourteen books each centring round a commandment or group of commandments within the general scheme. They cover respectively religious principles (The Book of Knowledge); the practice of the love of God in prayer and religious observance (The Book of Love); Sabbath and festivals (The Book of Times and Seasons); marriage and divorce (The Book of Women); forbidden relations, forbidden food (The Book of Holiness); vows and oaths (The Book of Specification); the year of Release, Jubilee, and Tithes (The Book of Plants of the Earth); public sacrifices and Temple worship (The Book of Service); private sacrifices (The Book of Sacrifice); laws of purity and impurity (The Book of Purity); laws of the relations between man and man: I, involving bodily injury or damage to property (The Book of Torts); II, sale and transfer (The Book of Acquisition); III, bailees, trustees, debts (The Book of Judgments); matters "within the jurisdiction of the Sanhedrin" [the supreme Jewish court]: the death penalty, laws of evidence, monarchy and war (The Book of Judges).

From this survey it will be seen that the name *Mishneh*

Torah is not exaggerated. The words (taken from Deut. xvii, 18; Josh. viii, 32) mean Repetition of the Law or "Deuteronomy," and they imply that Maimonides is doing for his age what Moses did for the generation of the Wilderness (Deut. i, 5), that is, repeating and summarizing the whole for the benefit of the new generation. But the phrase *Mishneh Torah* suggests even more than that. As we have had occasion to observe earlier (p. 24), the *Mishnah* was the first authoritative code for Jewry after the closing of the Biblical canon, and there seems little doubt that Maimonides, greatly daring but daring all the same, meant his book as a second *Mishnah*. Indeed, the account he gives in his introduction of the circumstances under which the *Mishnah* was compiled are exactly paralleled by the account he gives immediately after of the circumstances under which he compiled his own code. Both are works of consolidation consciously undertaken in order to stem the disintegration of Israel. Both were meant as a "summa" of Judaism and a "vade-mecum" for Jewry.

The *Code* is thus a guide to Jewish life in all its aspects and is in a sense Maimonides' chief work. It is the full fruit of his efforts to expound to his own people the nature of their spiritual heritage. But it is not only the culmination of Maimonides' own Rabbinical writings; it is a landmark in the history of Judaism itself. It is a complete, indeed the completest, expression of the whole compass of Jewish tradition. It is a code, but more comprehensive than any other code. It deals with everything (it will be noted that it includes, for example, the regulations governing Temple sacrifices); it leaves nothing aside as do the other codes. And it is also more coherent in itself. It is clear, concise and compelling.

By "compelling" is meant that it carries with it the note of natural authority. It is not a mere compilation of the views of others. Here, one feels, is the work of an original mind imposing order on chaos. Like Jeremy Bentham, Maimonides has no patience with incomplete or confused thought. At his touch the superfluous falls away and the essence stands out clear.

Yet there were points in the *Code* which seemed dangerous and gave rise to suspicion. There was no mention of authorities, and the student had to trust the author; and in some cases

the author seemed to have relied on his own judgment, in some few cases even to have reversed the judgment of his predecessors. In any case he had of set purpose given the student no means of judging since he had concealed his sources. It was no use his protesting that, on the contrary, he was only too anxious to have his errors corrected, and so far as his lack of mention of authorities was concerned would have liked himself to have added the requisite key for students. Had he not written that if he could summarize the Talmud in one chapter, he would not use two. Here is a man, cried his opponents, whose real aim is to obliterate traditional learning and to become a sole authority, to rule, and to survive, alone.

And there was another point which caused anxiety. Maimonides had prefaced to his *Code* a compendium of theology, metaphysics, physics and ethics which was all too reminiscent of the wisdom of the Greeks. He had denounced simple believers in the plain text of scripture as heretics and had seemed to have substituted for the physical resurrection a spiritual eternity of the rational soul. And he had not left all this in a mere preface. He had made it an integral part of the whole. It was actually one of the fourteen books of the *Code*, the "Mighty Hand" as it began to be called—the number 14 in Hebrew is "Yad" = hand—"the Mighty Hand which Moses showed in the sight of all Israel" (Deut. xxxiv, 12), blatant, unavoidable. And Maimonides had meant what he said. This doctrine was given as an integral part of Judaism, together with, and no less integral than, the detailed regulations of what prayers should be said on what occasions, and what meat was lawful and what unlawful.

But there were only mutterings now and the full storm was not to break yet. Except by a few extremists the book was received with extraordinary enthusiasm. Letters of thanks and congratulations, prefaced by page-long compliments, poured in from all the corners of the dispersion. The book was devoured by young and old, scholar and layman. It was taken up in study circles and conned idolatrously from Bagdad to Provence. It became an oracle, the "Urim and Thummim" (so we are told) brought out and consulted on any occasion of

doubt. The least of the titles by which its author was addressed was "Moses the man of God".

Maimonides' work was not yet done, however, and he pressed on. One more major work was required of him before the edifice he wished to build could be considered complete. He had spent ten years on the *Commentary* and ten years on the *Code*. The next ten years were to be spent on meditating and composing the *Guide*.

The Guide for the Perplexed (modern French version by Munk, Paris, 1855-6; Italian by Maroni, Florence, 1871-6; English by Friedlaender, London, 1881: frequently reprinted but without the notes; and German by Weiss, Leipzig, 1923) is composed of three parts. The first deals with Biblical homonyms and anthropomorphic terms, the attributes of God, and the theories of a school of Arabic theologians; the second with the Aristotelian philosophers' proofs of the existence of God, the doctrines of eternity and creation, and the phenomenon of prophecy; the third with the problems of evil, purpose, and providence, the reasons for the commandments and the nature of true worship. The whole makes up a comparatively short book (of about 400 octavo pages in the English version) and is thus roughly about the size of Aquinas' *Summa contra Gentiles* (not, of course, the huge *Summa Theologica*), or two-thirds of Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason*.

It is important to realize this. As Maimonides himself so often insists, the book is an aid to reflection rather than a detailed handbook. It is profound in its aperçus and thus suggestive, not exhaustive; it is its general grasp and guiding conceptions which tell. Maimonides claims that he has avoided no difficulty; but he also says emphatically time and again that the meaning of his book, either as a whole or in its particulars, is not to be seen on the surface but requires intimate and continuous study. It is difficult to believe that such statements are deliberate mystification. They are rather the plain fact. Maimonides believed that he knew the truth so far as truth is knowable to man. He wished to help those who had felt the difficulties he had felt himself. But his solutions had meaning only to those who had felt those difficulties personally, and if

given openly to the yet untroubled believer would be not helpful at all but destructive. Intellectual faith can come only after, and as a consequence of, intellectual doubt. The plain man in whom the doubt has not arisen had best be left undisturbed.

Maimonides is thus the type of religious "conciliator" as is indeed suggested by the very structure of the *Guide*. The first book opens with religious difficulties arising from the text of Scripture and goes on to discuss the value of an accepted *theological* solution. The second takes the stand of *science* and discusses the acceptability of the standpoint and results of the scientists, and it concludes (in the shape of an examination of the phenomenon of prophecy) with what is really an enquiry into the nature of knowledge. The third part sketches a general world view in which a purified religion guides man to his proper goal. There is a triplicity in the treatment which corresponds to the levels of perplexity in the mental development of everyone inclined to speculation. Puzzled by the source-book of religion and repelled by theology, he seeks salvation in science; only to discover that scientific explanations have no universal necessity and that science itself points to a deeper faith.

The *Guide* was written in Arabic but was translated into Hebrew in the master's own lifetime and in consultation with him. A second Hebrew version was turned very soon (early in the thirteenth century) into Latin; possibly by the collaboration of Jacob Anatoli (1194-1256), the son-in-law of the first translator from Arabic to Hebrew, and Michael Scot (died about 1235), one of the best known of the medieval translators from Arabic and Hebrew into Latin, both of whom had been invited by the "wonder of the world," Frederic II (Hohenstaufen), to join in the work centring around the new university he had created at Naples in 1224. The point is of some interest, as though the university itself was not long-lived, it had Thomas Aquinas among its students, and it may be that there the Angelic Doctor became acquainted not only with the doctrine of Maimonides but also with his text. But whether this was so or not, the *Guide* in its Latin version spread rapidly through the Christian world, and, as we shall have occasion to note

later, played a significant part in the building up of the thought of individual schoolmen and of the whole imposing edifice of scholasticism itself.

I end this survey of the principal works of Maimonides with the *Letter on Astrology* (best ed. by A. Marx in *Hebrew Union College Annual*, vol. III; cf. also his *Studies in Jewish History and Booklore*, New York, 1944). Interesting in itself, this letter is typical of many sent by the sage in reply to queries addressed to him from all over the Jewish world on an endless variety of subjects. It is a reply to "the wise men of Marseilles" and re-states in a forceful fashion the unalterable basis of an intelligent faith. There may be Biblical or Talmudical sentences from which belief in astrology can be argued, or individual opinion in favour of its truth. But it is both intrinsically absurd and incompatible with the freedom of choice upon which the moral life and all religion depends. Texts may say, or appear to say, what they like, but "man must never throw his understanding behind him [i.e., surrender his private judgment]; for the eyes are directed forward and not back" (26a).